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Head of Cyber Operations (Defence)

Cabinet Office

Apply before 11:55 pm on Thursday 26th November 2026

Cabinet Office

Reference number

486783

Salary

£71,734 - £93,755

This role offers Government Digital and Data Pay allowance and offers above the band minimum are subject to our assessment of your skills and experience as demonstrated at interview. Salaries over the band minimum will be paid as a non-pensionable allowance.

A Civil Service Pension with an employer contribution of 28.97%

Job grade

Grade 6

Contract type

Permanent

Business area

CO - Digital

Type of role

Digital

Working pattern

Full-time

Number of jobs available

1

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Location

Bristol, Glasgow, London, York

About the job

Job summary

The Cabinet Office supports the Prime Minister and ensures the effective running of government. It is also the corporate headquarters for government, in partnership with HM Treasury, and takes the lead in certain critical policy areas.
We are the Cabinet Office s cyber security team, and our mission is to secure their department against cyberthreats. We protect our nationwide internal IT infrastructure, and high-profile citizen-facing digital services such as GOV.UK

Please note that this role requires SC clearance, which would normally need 5 years UK residency in the past 5 years. This is not an absolute requirement, but supplementary checks may be needed where individuals have not lived in the UK for that period. This may mean your security clearance (and therefore your appointment) will take longer or, in some cases, not be possible.

Job description

As the Head of Cyber Operations Defence, you will:

- Lead the Cabinet Office s cyber security operations function, by providing strategic direction and coordinating day-to-day delivery of threat intelligence, threat detection and incident response.
- Be responsible for leadership and line management of senior and lead analysts.
- Work closely with the Deputy Director of Cyber and information Security (CISO) to design, and drive implementation and delivery of, the department s cyber security strategy and roadmap
- Deputise for the Deputy Director of Cyber and Information Security (CISO) as required, including attending the Digital Senior Leadership Team, Technical Design Authority, and programme boards
- Oversee and support the technical response to major cyber security incidents and critical vulnerabilities impacting the Cabinet Office

Identify and deliver opportunities for continual improvement of the security operations function and identify areas for maturity building in line with best practice in government sector

Brief senior stakeholders on cyber security threats, vulnerabilities, incidents, and mitigations

Work closely alongside other cyber and information security functions, supporting the continual improvement of wider capabilities

Work with stakeholders from across the Cabinet Office to ensure an end-to-end approach to cyber security, and ensure that cyber security is embedded in other central and local functions

Work with Government Security Group, the National Technical Authorities (e.g., NCSC) and law enforcement to ensure knowledge sharing and collaboration

Contribute to the overall development of the Cabinet Office Digital and the Government Security profession

Budget & Resource Management: You will take full ownership of the team's budget, ensuring resources are strategically allocated to drive high-impact outcomes.

Person specification

Who you are

We re interested in people who have:

Experience leading an operational cyber security function, or the delivery of cyber security capabilities in an organisation

A comprehensive and in-depth understanding of cyber threats, vulnerabilities and mitigations, including a technical background and awareness of modern threat landscape, including emerging threats

High levels of personal resilience, remaining calm under pressure with the ability to think and act strategically, developing practical, creative and innovative solutions, business models and approaches, and implementing these

Experience building, developing, and managing diverse and high-performing teams

Experience leading operational and strategic planning

Experience building and implementing strong operational processes

Familiarity with setting, monitoring and reporting measurable performance objectives

A risk-based approach to decision making

Excellent communication skills, and a track record of delivering clear and concise written and verbal communications to senior stakeholders on complex issues

An ability to form strong working relationships, influence others, and coordinate activities across multiple teams

A problem-solving mindset, and an ability to analyse complex issues and identify simple and deliverable solutions which balance quality and long-term sustainability with need for rapid delivery

It s desirable that you have:

Professional certifications such as CISSP, CISM, or equivalent.

An understanding of new and emerging digital technologies and the opportunities they provide to improve the delivery of public services in the UK and their security implications

Ability to share expertise and promote diversity while navigating a complex organisation

Additional information:

Cabinet Office policy is that a minimum 60% of your working time should be spent at your principal workplace. For some roles, due to their nature and the business need, this may be up to 100%. Requirements to attend other locations for official business will also count towards this level of attendance.

This role is available in London, Bristol, Glasgow and York. Existing CO staff who wish to apply can retain their current location if successful.

Behaviours

We'll assess you against these behaviours during the selection process:

Seeing the Big Picture

Changing and Improving

Making Effective Decisions

Leadership

Benefits

Alongside your salary of £71,734, Cabinet Office contributes £20,781 towards you being a member of the Civil Service Defined Benefit Pension scheme. Find out what benefits a Civil Service Pension provides (opens in a new window).

Learning and development tailored to your role.

An environment with flexible working options.

A culture encouraging inclusion and diversity.

A Civil Service Pension which provides an attractive pension, benefits for dependants and employer contributions of 28.97%.

A minimum of 25 days of paid annual leave, increasing by one day per year up to a maximum of 30.

Things you need to know

Artificial intelligence

Artificial intelligence can be a useful tool to support your application, however, all examples and statements provided must be truthful, factually accurate and taken directly from your own experience. Where plagiarism has been identified (presenting the ideas and experiences of others, or generated by artificial intelligence, as your own) applications may be withdrawn and internal candidates may be subject to disciplinary action. Please see our candidate guidance (opens in a new window) for more information on appropriate and inappropriate use.

Selection process details

This vacancy is using Success Profiles (opens in a new window), and will assess your Behaviours and Experience.

Application process

As part of your application, you will be required to provide a CV setting out your career history and qualifications, highlighting specific responsibilities and achievements that are relevant to the essential criteria in the person specification section of the job advert.

Please use your statement of suitability to (in no more than 750 words) to explain how you consider your personal skills, qualities and experience provide evidence of your suitability for the role, with particular reference to the essential criteria in the person specification section of the job advert.

Should a large number of applications be received, an initial sift may be conducted using the behaviour Leadership. Candidates who pass the initial sift may be progressed to a full sift, or progressed straight to assessment/ interview.

Interview

During the interview stage you will be assessed on the behaviour success profiles.

Interviews are to be held in person and will include a fireside chat with the Chief Information Security Officer (CISO) and Acting Head of Cyber Operations.

Expected timeline (subject to change)

Expected sift date week commencing 30/11/2026
Expected interview date/s Week Commencing 14/12/2026
Interview location - To be Confirmed

Please note: any dates included are subject to change and any candidates successful at the sift and invited to interview will be provided with updated information.

Reasonable adjustments

If a person with disabilities is put at a substantial disadvantage compared to a non-disabled person, we have a duty to make reasonable changes to our processes.

If you need a change to be made so that you can make your application, you should contact menurecruitment.grs@cabinetoffice.gov.uk

Further information
If you are experiencing accessibility problems with any attachments on this advert, please contact the email address in the 'contact point for applicants' section.

Please note that this role requires SC clearance, which would normally need 5 years UK residency in the past 5 years. This is not an absolute requirement, but supplementary checks may be needed where individuals have not lived in the UK for that period. This may mean your security clearance (and therefore your appointment) will take longer or, in some cases, not be possible.

For further information on National Security Vetting please visit the Demystifying Vetting website.

Please note terms and conditions are attached. Please take time to read the document to determine how these may affect you.

Any move to Cabinet Office from another employer will mean you can no longer access childcare vouchers. This includes moves between government departments. You may however be eligible for other government schemes, including Tax Free Childcare. Determine your eligibility at: https://www.childcarechoices.gov.uk.

A reserve list will be held for a period of 12 months, from which further appointments can be made.

This role is full time only. Applicants who wish to work an alternative pattern are welcome to apply however your preferred working pattern may not be available and you should discuss this with the vacancy holder before applying.

Feedback will only be provided if you attend an interview or assessment.

Security

Successful candidates must undergo a basic (or equivalent) criminal record check.

Successful candidates must meet the security requirements before they can be appointed. The level of security needed is security check (opens in a new window).

See our vetting charter (opens in a new window).

People working with government assets must complete baseline personnel security standard (opens in new window) checks.

Nationality requirements

This job is broadly open to the following groups:

- UK nationals
- nationals of the Republic of Ireland
- nationals of Commonwealth countries who have the right to work in the UK
- nationals of the EU, Switzerland, Norway, Iceland or Liechtenstein and family members of those nationalities with settled or pre-settled status under the European Union Settlement Scheme (EUSS) (opens in a new window)
- nationals of the EU, Switzerland, Norway, Iceland or Liechtenstein and family members of those nationalities who have made a valid application for settled or pre-settled status under the European Union Settlement Scheme (EUSS)
- individuals with limited leave to remain or indefinite leave to remain who were eligible to apply for EUSS on or before 31 December 2020
- Turkish nationals, and certain family members of Turkish nationals, who have accrued the right to work in the Civil Service

Further information on nationality requirements (opens in a new window)

Working for the Civil Service

The Civil Service Code (opens in a new window) sets out the standards of behaviour expected of civil servants.

We recruit by merit on the basis of fair and open competition, as outlined in the Civil Service Commission's recruitment principles (opens in a new window).

The Civil Service embraces diversity and promotes equal opportunities. As such, we run a Disability Confident Scheme (DCS) for candidates with disabilities who meet the minimum selection criteria.

The Civil Service also offers a Redeployment Interview Scheme to civil servants who are at risk of redundancy, and who meet the minimum requirements for the advertised vacancy.

Diversity and Inclusion

The Civil Service is committed to attract, retain and invest in talent wherever it is found. To learn more please see the Civil Service People Plan (opens in a new window) and the Civil Service Diversity and Inclusion Strategy (opens in a new window).

Apply and further information

This vacancy is part of the Great Place to Work for Veterans (opens in a new window) initiative.

The Civil Service welcomes applications from people who have recently left prison or have an unspent conviction. Read more about prison leaver recruitment (opens in new window).

Once this job has closed, the job advert will no longer be available. You may want to save a copy for your records.

Contact point for applicants

Job contact :

Name : CO Digital Recruitment

Email : codigitalrecruitment@cabinetoffice.gov.uk

Recruitment team

Email : menurecruitment.grs@cabinetoffice.gov.uk

Further information

Appointment to the Civil Service is governed by the Civil Service Commission s Recruitment Principles.
If you feel that your application has not been treated in accordance with the Recruitment Principles, and wish to make a complaint, then in the first instance you should contact Government Recruitment Service at: cabinetofficerecruitment.grs@cabinetoffice.gov.uk.
If you are not satisfied with the response that you receive, then you can contact the Civil Service Commission at: info@csc.gov.uk.
For further information on the Recruitment Principles, and bringing a complaint to the Civil Service Commission, please visit their website at: https://civilservicecommission.independent.gov.uk.

Civil Service Commission

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